

The atmosphere

Our planet is surrounded by a thin blanket of gases called the atmosphere. Weather only happens in the very lowest layer, the troposphere.

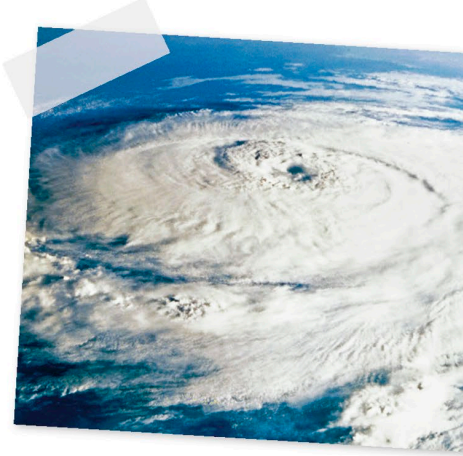
Satellites are stationed in the exosphere, 600 to 300 miles (1,000 to 500 km) from Earth.

The thermosphere is between 300 and 55 miles (500 and 85 km) from Earth. Here, you'll find the aurora lights and the International Space Station.

The mesosphere is between 55 and 30 miles (85 and 50 km) from Earth. Some of the ozone layer and meteorites are found here.

The stratosphere is between 30 and 7 miles (50 and 12 km) from Earth. Nacreous clouds sometimes appear in the lower level, and passenger planes often fly this high.

All our weather happens in the troposphere.



Weather forecasts

Weather experts use satellites to help them make more accurate forecasts. This satellite photograph shows a hurricane over an ocean.

The ancient Greeks used to think that wind was the Earth breathing in and out. Now we know it is simply air on the move.